



SESSION 7 | COURSE 5140602

Nuptiality, Union Formation, and Household & Family Structure

Fundamental Demographic Analysis | College of Population Studies, Chulalongkorn University

Instructor: Asst. Prof. Dr. Ruttiya Bhula-or | 2026 Revised Syllabus

By the End of This Session, You Will Be Able To...



Distinguish household from family, and describe how their statistical definitions have evolved.



Map living arrangements and marital-status categories across the life course.



Compute and interpret the crude marriage rate and related nuptiality measures.



Explain the rise of cohabitation, delayed marriage, and one-person households with current evidence.



Critically assess how censuses and surveys measure “family” today, including LGBTQ+ unions and blended families.



Apply these concepts to real 2024-2026 Thai and global data.

Agenda — 180 Minutes



BLOCK 1

Households, families & the measurement of marital status



BREAK

15-minute break



BLOCK 2

Measuring marriage — and the rise of new union forms



BLOCK 3

Solo living, evolving family definitions, group work & practice

Family Life Is Being Redefined — In Real Time

23 Jan 2025

Thailand's Marriage Equality Act took effect — the first law of its kind in Southeast Asia, instantly changing who counts as “married” in Thai civil registration.

29%

of all U.S. households now hold just one person — an all-time high (Dec. 2025) — echoing a global rise in solo living documented across dozens of countries.

Sources: UN OHCHR (2025); U.S. Census Bureau (2025), Families and Living Arrangements.



Block 1

Households, Families & Marital Status

Why demographers separate the household (a co-residence unit) from the family (a kinship unit) — and how both are measured.

Household ≠ Family



HOUSEHOLD

A co-residence and/or housekeeping unit: one person or a group — related or unrelated — who share a dwelling and, typically, provisioning (e.g., a common budget or meals).

Statistical unit — defined operationally for the census or survey. Boundaries can be a dwelling, a budget, or an eating arrangement, and are set by the statistical agency.



FAMILY

A group of two or more people related by blood, marriage, civil union, adoption, or (increasingly) legally recognized partnership — whether or not they co-reside.

Kinship unit — a family can span several households (e.g., a migrant parent abroad), and a household can contain zero, one, or several families.

Evolving Definitions of “Household”



1. Housekeeping-unit era

Early 20th-c. censuses: household = people sharing meals/food budget (“housekeeping” concept).



2. Dwelling-unit era

Mid-20th-c. UN recommendations shift toward co-residence in a shared housing unit, easier to enumerate.



3. De jure vs. de facto

Agencies must choose: count usual residents (de jure) or who slept there last night (de facto)?



4. 21st-century complexity

Multi-locational, digitally connected, and “living apart together” arrangements strain the one-dwelling model.

Household Types Used in Demographic Analysis



One-person

A single individual living alone.



Nuclear / couple

Married or partnered couple, with or without children.



Extended

Couple/parent-child core plus other relatives (grandparents, siblings).



Single-parent

One parent co-residing with unmarried children.



Skip-generation

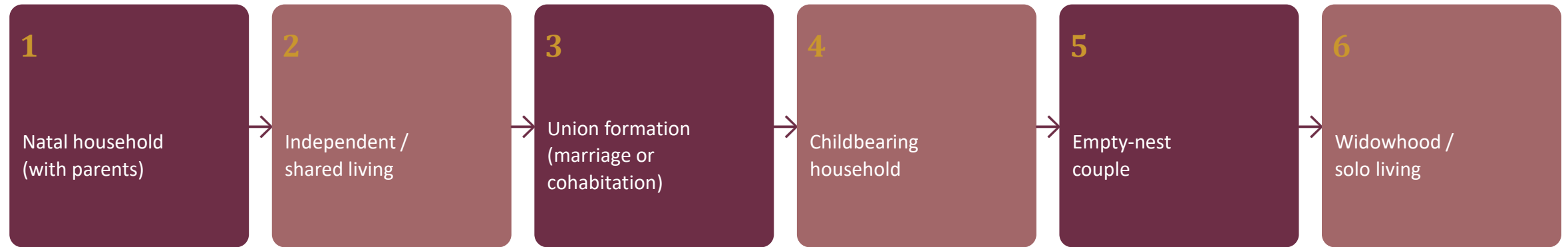
Grandparent(s) and grandchildren, parents absent (common with labor migration).



Non-family / composite

Unrelated individuals sharing a dwelling (roommates, dormitories).

Stages of Living Arrangements Across the Life Course



Individuals move through — and often back through — these stages non-linearly; solo living and cohabitation increasingly interrupt the “classic” sequence (see Blocks 2–3).

Marital-Status Definitions (I): The Basic Split



NEVER-MARRIED / SINGLE

Persons who have not, as of the reference date, entered a legally or customarily recognized marriage. In most tabulations this is a de jure legal-status category — it says nothing about whether the person is currently in a cohabiting union.

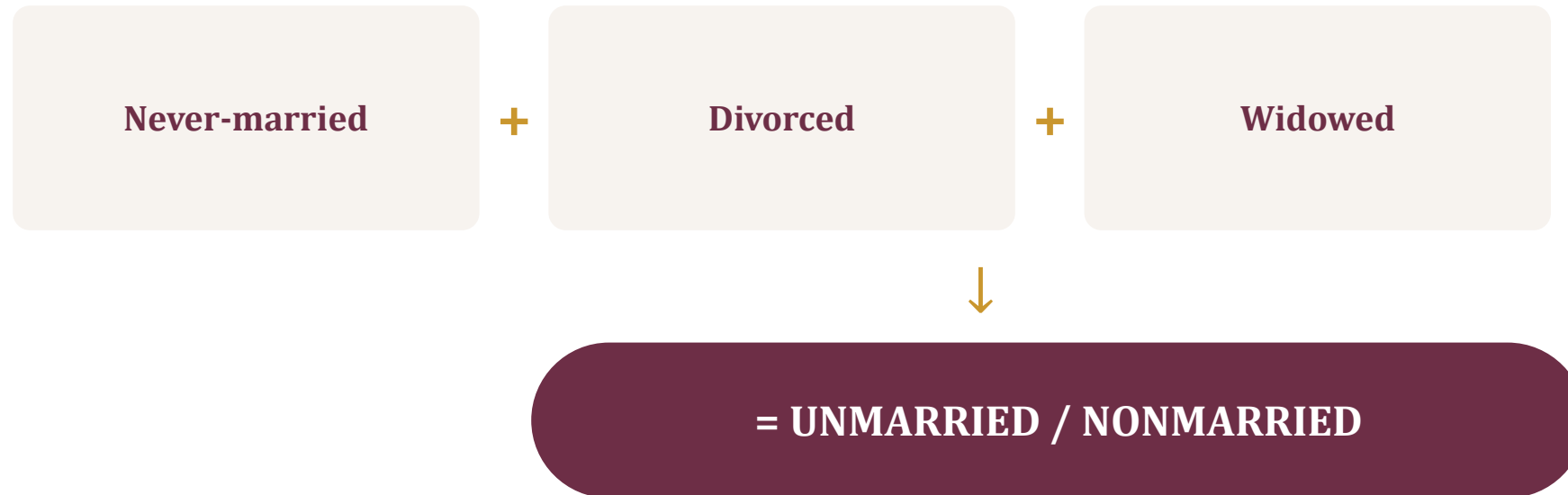


EVER-MARRIED

Anyone who has entered marriage at least once, regardless of current status. It is the union of three subgroups: currently married, divorced, and widowed — the complement of never-married.

Marital-Status Definitions (II): “Unmarried / Nonmarried”

A composite analytic category used when the research question is exposure to marriage risk or lack of a co-resident spouse — not legal history.



Used, e.g., in singulate-mean-age-at-marriage calculations and in studies of solo/non-spousal living arrangements.

Three Things Demographers Are Often Asked to Assume — Incorrectly



“Household and family are the same thing.”

They are not. A live-in domestic worker, boarder, or unrelated roommate is part of a household's headcount but not the family; a migrant parent abroad remains part of the family but not the household. Conflating the two silently changes what a statistic measures.



“Marital-status categories are stable across time and countries.”

Legal definitions of “married” change (e.g., Thailand's 2025 Marriage Equality Act), age at which marriage is legally possible varies by country, and some jurisdictions register religious or customary unions civil registries never see. Cross-national or over-time comparisons need explicit definitional footnotes.



“Falling marriage rates mean falling partnership.”

A declining crude marriage rate can coexist with a stable or rising rate of cohabiting unions. The CMR only counts legal marriages — it says nothing about whether people are pairing up in other, unregistered forms of union (Block 2).

Marriage Equality and the Redefinition of “Married”

- On 23 January 2025, Thailand's Marriage Equality Act (amending the Civil and Commercial Code) took effect, granting same-sex couples the same legal marriage rights as different-sex couples.
- Thailand became the first country in Southeast Asia — and the third in Asia — to legalize same-sex marriage.
- Couples may now register at any of Thailand's ~928 district offices or 94 embassies — directly changing what civil-registration “marriage” counts capture.
- Demographic implication: crude marriage rates, spousal-benefit statistics, and household rosters must now be interpreted under a broadened legal definition of a marital union.

1st

country in Southeast Asia to legalize same-sex marriage

Source: UN Human Rights Office (OHCHR Bangkok, 2025); Library of Congress Global Legal Monitor (2025).

Discuss in Pairs (5 minutes)



- If Thailand's civil registry now records same-sex marriages, what happens to time-series comparability of the crude marriage rate before vs. after Jan 2025?
- Should a census “marital status” question be about legal status, or about who you currently live with as a partner? What is lost either way?
- Name one group whose living arrangement doesn't fit neatly into a single household (e.g., a migrant worker's family) — how would you count them?



Break

Back at the top of the hour — next: measuring marriage, and the rise of cohabitation.



Block 2

Measuring Marriage — and the Rise of New Union Forms

From the crude marriage rate to cohabitation and delayed marriage: how nuptiality measures keep pace with changing behavior.

The Crude Marriage Rate (CMR)

$$\text{CMR} = (\text{M} / \text{P}) \times 1,000$$

Thailand, 2023: 279,748 registered marriages; mid-year population $\approx$ 66.05 million.

$$\text{CMR} = (279,748 / 66,050,000) \times 1,000 \approx 4.2 \text{ per } 1,000$$

M = number of marriages registered during the year. P = mid-year total population. Result expressed per 1,000 population.

Strengths & limits: CMR is simple and needs minimal data, but it is “crude” — the denominator includes children, the already-married, and others not at risk of marrying, so it cannot be compared cleanly across populations with different age or marital-status structures. General and age-specific marriage rates (next slide) correct for this.

Marriage count: NSO Thailand, Statistical Yearbook Thailand 2025 (Dept. of Provincial Administration data).

Beyond the Crude Rate: Standard Nuptiality Measures



General Marriage Rate (GMR)

Marriages ÷ unmarried population aged 15+ (×1,000). Restricts denominator to those legally at risk of marrying.



Age-Specific Marriage Rate (ASMR)

Marriages to persons age x ÷ unmarried population age x. Reveals the age pattern of first and remarriage.



Singulate Mean Age at Marriage (SMAM)

Derived from % single by age (Hajnal method). Summarizes the typical age at first marriage without needing full marital-history data.



Total First Marriage Rate (TFMR)

Sum of age-specific first-marriage rates. The nuptiality analogue of the TFR — a period 'cohort' measure of marriage propensity.

How the Singulate Mean Age at Marriage Is Read in Practice

The Hajnal method estimates the average number of years lived single (before age 50) directly from the proportions of men and women still “never-married” in each five-year age group of a single census — no full marriage-history data needed.

Real published data point	Value
Age 25-29, % never-married (female)	69 . 0%
Age 30-34, % never-married (female)	41 . 9%
Age 35-39, % never-married (female)	22 . 6%

Reading the pattern:

The steep drop from 69% single at 25-29 to 22.6% at 35-39 shows most first marriages are concentrated in the early-30s window — pushing the computed SMAM well above 27-28 years, consistent with Singapore's reported median age at first marriage of 28.8 (female) / 30.4 (male).

Why it matters: SMAM lets demographers compare typical marriage timing across countries and years even when longitudinal marriage-history surveys don't exist — using only a standard census age-by-marital-status table.

Source: Singapore Department of Statistics, *Census of Population 2020, Statistical Release 1 (marital status tables)*; Department of Statistics Singapore (2021), *Population Trends*.

A Second Real CMR Calculation, Outside Thailand

$$\text{CMR} = (\text{M} / \text{P}) \times 1,000$$

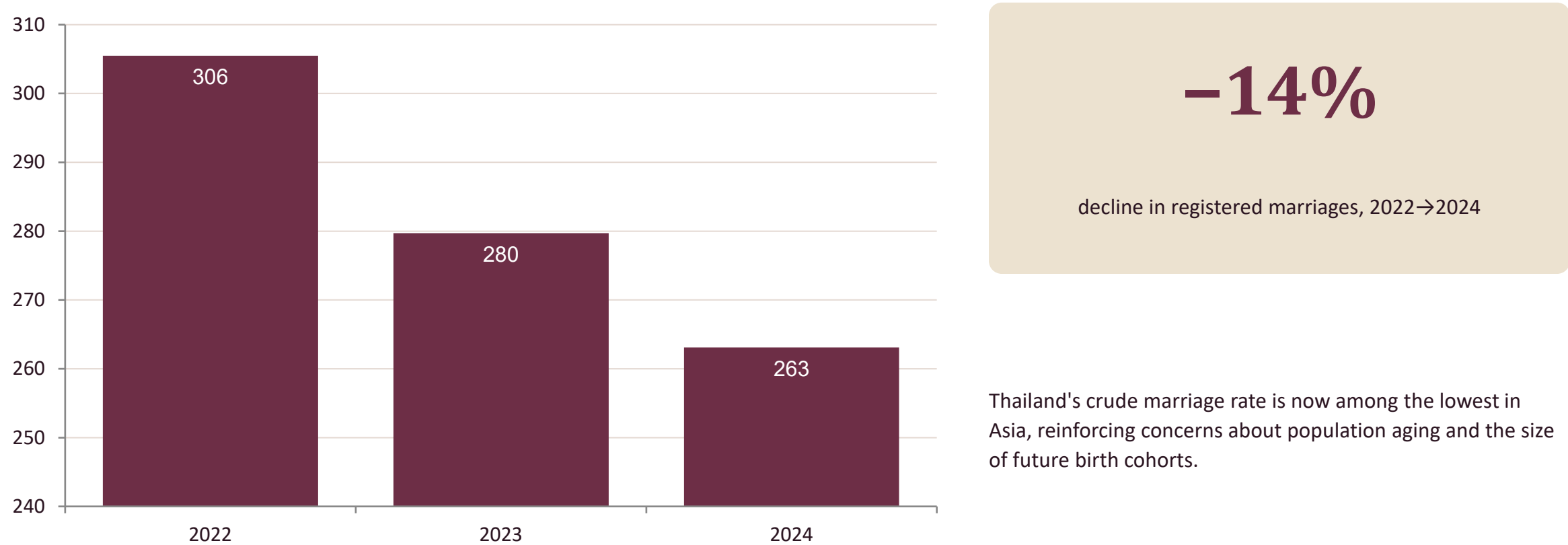
Japan, 2024: 499,999 registered marriages; total population $\approx$ 124.3 million.

$$\text{CMR} = (499,999 / 124,300,000) \times 1,000 \approx 4.0 \text{ per } 1,000$$

Context: 2024's marriages were up 2.2% on 2023 — the second consecutive annual rise — but that 499,999 is still only about 44% of Japan's 1972 peak of 1.099 million marriages. Demographers read the recent uptick mainly as pandemic-postponed weddings finally taking place, not a reversal of the decades-long decline (compare to Thailand's CMR $\approx$ 4.2, Slide 17 — both countries now sit in a similarly low range, despite very different marriage-registration systems).

Sources: ISVD (2025), Japan's 2025 births analysis (marriage series); Statistics Bureau of Japan / Ministry of Health, Labour and Welfare, Vital Statistics (2025).

Registered Marriages Are Falling Faster Than Population



Source: National Statistical Office of Thailand, Statistical Yearbook Thailand 2023 & 2025 (Dept. of Provincial Administration registration data). nso.go.th

Cohabitation & Non-Marital Unions

Cohabitation — two partners sharing a household and an intimate relationship without a legal marriage — has moved from marginal to mainstream across much of the OECD since the 1970s.



Pre-marital stage

A step before (or instead of) formal marriage, common in North America and much of Europe.



Marriage alternative

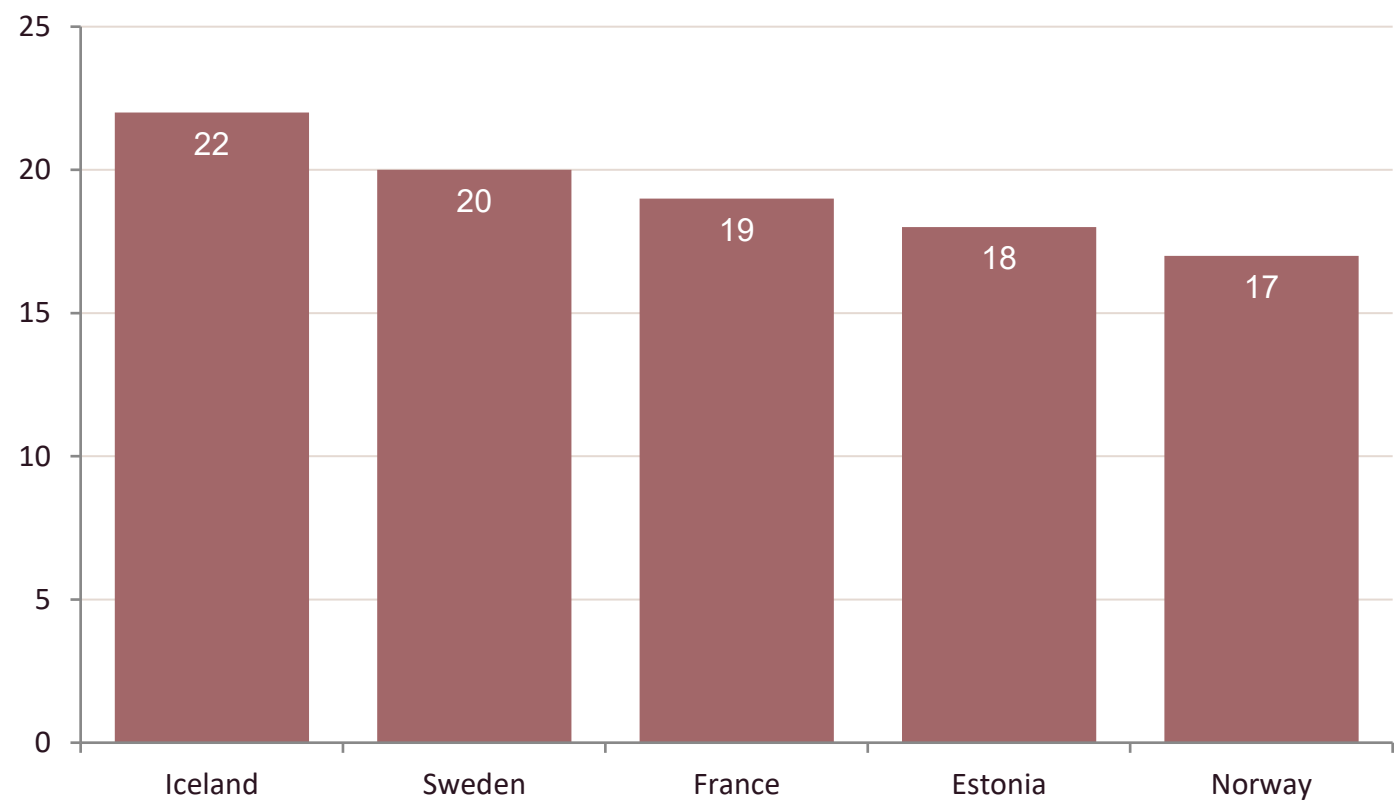
A long-term substitute for marriage, most advanced in the Nordic countries.



Measurement challenge

Many surveys only add explicit “living with partner” categories after cohabitation becomes common — lagging the behavioral change.

The “Cohabitation Frontier”



64%

of women worldwide were married or in a union in 2024 —
down from 69% in 1970

The fall is concentrated in Europe, North America & parts of Africa — not a uniform global trend.

Sources: OECD (2024), Society at a Glance 2024: Marriage and Divorce; Our World in Data, Marriages and Divorces (2024).

Delayed and Declining Marriage: Why?



Education expansion

Longer schooling, esp. for women, postpones entry into marriage markets.



Female labor-force participation

Economic independence reduces the material incentive to marry early.



Urbanization & housing cost

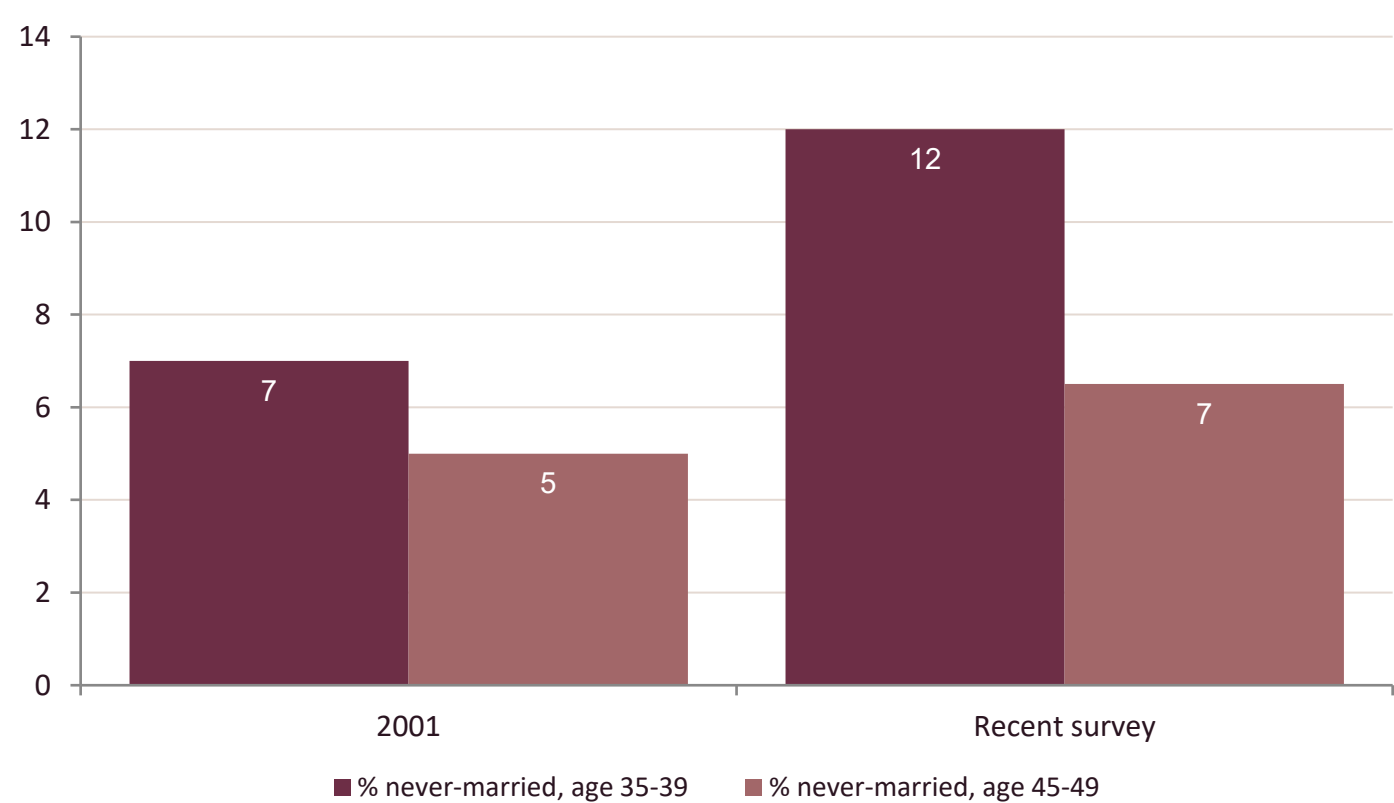
City living raises the cost of establishing an independent marital household.



Changing gender norms

Rising individualism and shifting norms around partnership and childbearing.

More Thai Women Are Staying Never-Married



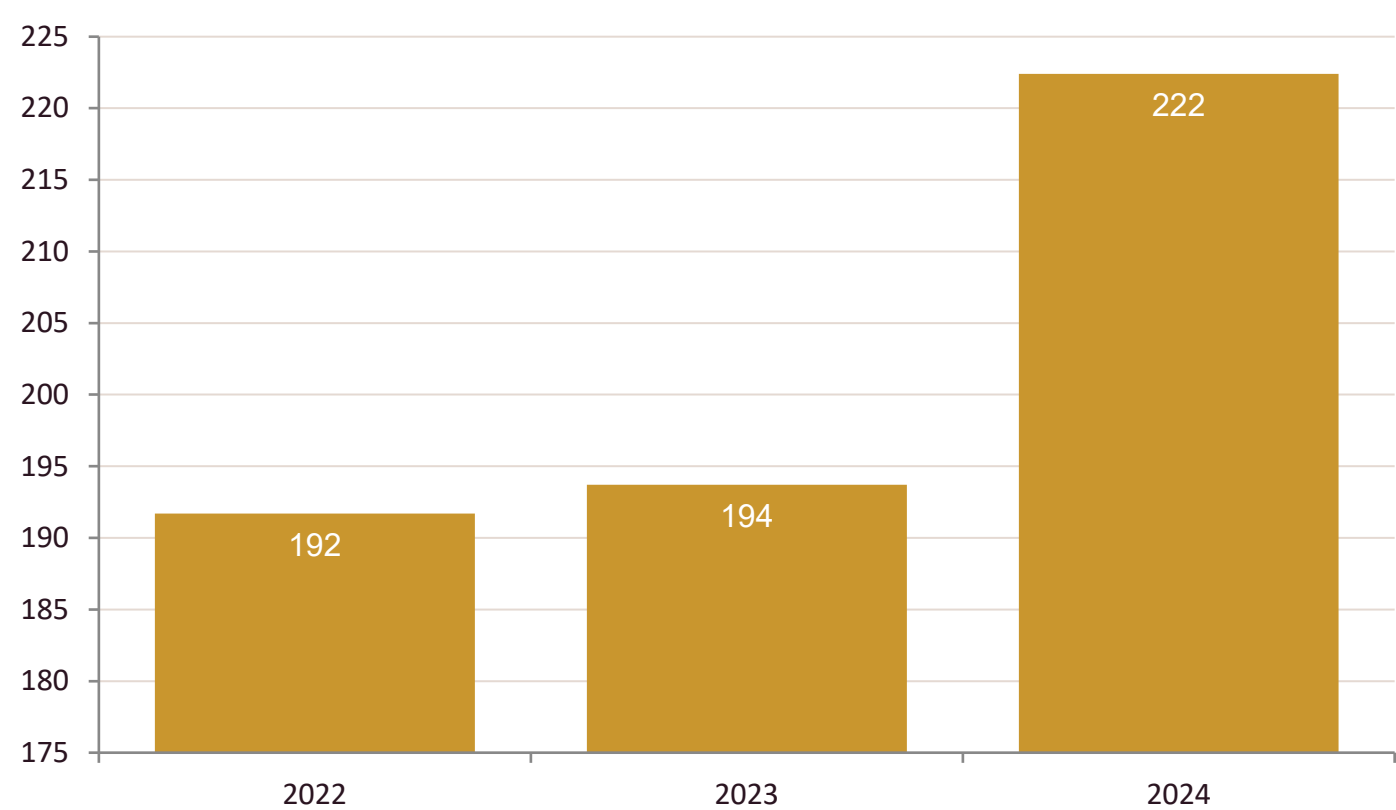
9%

of women aged 15-49 in Thailand had never married — up 5.5 points since 2001

A related 2024 study finds remarriage after divorce/widowhood is becoming more selective and later-timed, reshaping mid-life household composition.

Sources: Chulalongkorn Univ. College of Population Studies, in Bangkok Post (2018); Pothisiri, Teerawichitchainan & Kaewbuadee (2024), J. of Family Issues, doi.org/10.1177/0192513X231155659.

A Rare Marriage Rebound — But From a Record Low



4.4

per 1,000 crude marriage rate, 2024 — down from 8.7 in 1995

Marriages rose 14.8% in 2024 to 222,400 — the sharpest increase in five years — but total marriages had already halved from their 1996 peak of 434,900. Analysts attribute the rebound partly to pandemic-delayed weddings and a rising share of international marriages (9.3% of the total).

Sources: The Korea Herald (2025), 30-year report shows marriages halved; Statistics Korea (KOSTAT), Vital Statistics 2024.

Try It: Compute a General Marriage Rate

$$\text{CMR} = (M / P) \times 1,000$$

$$\text{GMR} = (M / U15+) \times 1,000$$

A province registers 4,200 marriages in one year. Mid-year population 1,850,000; unmarried population aged 15+ is 620,000.

$$\text{Step 1} - \text{CMR} = (4,200 / 1,850,000) \times 1,000 \approx 2.27$$

$$\text{Step 2} - \text{GMR} = (4,200 / 620,000) \times 1,000 \approx 6.77$$

Discuss: why is the GMR roughly 3x the CMR here? What does that gap tell you about this province's age structure?

Assigned Cases

Group size: Groups of 2-3 **Time:** 10 min prep + 3 groups × 5 min report-back + 5-10 min synthesis discussion

1

What is driving this jurisdiction's marriage/union pattern, and which measurement challenge from today's session (e.g., a legal-definition change, an age-structure distortion, or an administrative-data gap) does it create for demographers?

2

What is one policy or statistical-system implication (e.g., civil-registration redesign, minimum-marriage-age enforcement, or flagging a time-series discontinuity)?

GROUP 1

Thailand — Marriage Equality

The 2025 Marriage Equality Act legalized same-sex marriage — the first in Southeast Asia — while registered marriages fell 14% (2022→2024: 305.5k → 279.7k → 263.1k).

UN OHCHR (2025); NSO Thailand, Statistical Yearbook 2025.

GROUP 2

Japan & South Korea — Decline, Then a Blip

Japan: 499,999 marriages in 2024 (CMR ≈ 4.0), just 44% of the 1972 peak. South Korea: CMR fell from 8.7 (1995) to 4.4 (2024) despite a 14.8% one-year rebound.

ISVD (2025); The Korea Herald (2025); KOSTAT.

GROUP 3

Niger — Early & Near-Universal Marriage

76% of girls in Niger are married before age 18 (28% before 15) — the world's highest child-marriage prevalence, reflecting a very different nuptiality regime and data-collection context.

UNICEF (2024), Child Marriage Data.

Discuss: Measuring Union Formation vs. Marriage



- If a growing share of unions are cohabiting rather than married, what happens to the CMR as a proxy for “family formation”?
- How might Thailand's Marriage Equality Act interact with cohabitation trends among LGBTQ+ couples who previously had no legal option to marry?
- What survey question would you add to capture cohabiting unions without asking directly about marital status?



Block 3

Solo Living & the Changing Meaning of “Family”

One-person households, LGBTQ+ unions, and blended families are testing how censuses and surveys define family in 2026.

The Rise of the One-Person Household

Solo living — once concentrated among older widows/widowers — is now rising fastest among young and middle-aged adults across both high- and middle-income countries.



Delayed union formation

Postponed marriage/cohabitation leaves a longer independent-living stage.



Rising incomes & housing supply

Enables affording to live alone rather than with kin or roommates.



Population aging

Longer life expectancy plus gender gaps in mortality raises late-life solo living.

One-Person Households: A Global Turning Point

29%

of all U.S. households (39.7 million) held one person in 2025 — up from 20% in 1975, an all-time high.

47%

of Danish households are single-person — among the highest shares in the world.

90+

countries and territories analyzed in a 2024 global study of lifetime exposure to solo living using census microdata.

Sources: U.S. Census Bureau (2025), *Families and Living Arrangements* press release; Esteve, A., & Reher, D. S. (2024), *Population and Development Review*, 50(1), 211-232, doi.org/10.1111/padr.12603.



LGBTQ+ Unions

Instruments must separate the sex/gender of the respondent and of the partner, and distinguish married from unmarried same-sex partners.

The U.S. American Community Survey only added a same-sex-spouse/partner distinction in 2019 — decades after same-sex cohabitation was common.

Thailand's 2025 Marriage Equality Act means the next census must decide how to phrase the relationship-to-reference-person question for same-sex spouses.

Without this category, same-sex married couples are miscoded as “unrelated individuals” or “roommates,” undercounting real households.



Blended & Step-Families

A household roster listing only “head, spouse, children” misses step-, half-, and multi-partner-fertility children living together.

A child living with a biological parent, a step-parent, and half-siblings from two different unions needs more than one relationship code to be captured accurately.

Standard rosters often force enumerators to record only the closest kin tie to the reference person, hiding the full sibling/step-sibling structure.

This matters for child-support, custody, and household-size statistics, which can misstate true co-residence patterns.



Multi-Generational Households

Three (or more) co-resident generations — common with population aging and labor migration — strain rosters designed around a single nuclear “head.”

Skip-generation households (grandparent + grandchildren, parents working abroad) require the roster to record generation and caregiving role, not just kinship label.

Multi-generational co-residence is rising in rapidly aging societies (including Thailand) as adult children support elderly parents — a household form the classic nuclear typology undercounts.

Pension and health-policy planning needs accurate multi-generational household counts to size intra-family old-age support versus public-transfer need.



Living Apart Together & Transnational Families

Committed partners who deliberately maintain separate households, and families split across borders, are invisible to co-residence-based family measures.

Living Apart Together (LAT): committed couples who choose not to share a dwelling appear as two separate one-person households in a co-residence-based census.

Transnational families: a family split across a migrant parent abroad and children at home spans two households and often two countries — no single national census captures the whole family.

Both cases show why demographers increasingly triangulate census, survey, and administrative/digital data rather than relying on the household roster alone.

How Measurement Choices Move the Numbers

1.4 million

same-sex couple households counted in the United States in 2024 — nearly double the 2005 count, following clearer survey categories introduced after 2015 and 2019.

Key takeaway: Part of this rise is real behavioral change; part is measurement catching up — more confident reporting after legal recognition, and better-designed survey categories. Demographers must separate the two before reading a time series as a trend.

Source: U.S. Census Bureau (2026), More Female Than Male Same-Sex Couple Households in the United States in 2024, census.gov/library/stories/2026/04/same-sex-couples.html.

Thailand's Households Are Shrinking

Average household size has fallen for decades as fertility declines, urban youth live independently longer, and the population ages.

5.2→3.0

average household size, Thailand, 1980 → 2022
(persons per household).

28.7%

of Thai households were single-person in 2024 —
the fastest-growing household type through 2029.

26.30M

total households counted in the 2025 Population
and Housing Census.

Sources: Euromonitor International (2024), Households: Thailand; National Statistical Office of Thailand (2025), Preliminary Results of the 2025 Population and Housing Census.

Thailand's Rising Divorce Rate — A Complication for “Marriage” Statistics

As registered marriages fall, registered divorces have simultaneously risen — a reminder that CMR trends alone cannot describe the health of “marriage” as an institution.

121,011

registered divorces in Thailand in 2020.

147,340

registered divorces in 2023 — a continued increase.

~1 in 3

marriages in Thailand now ends in divorce, among the highest shares in Southeast Asia.

Implication: a demographer reading only a falling CMR could wrongly conclude marital instability is also falling. Divorce, remarriage, and cohabitation data must be read alongside marriage data to interpret “family change” correctly.

Sources: Khaosod English (2023), A Decade of Divorces in Thailand Reaches 1.3 Million Partners; Statista (2024), Thailand: Number of Registered Divorces.

Family Measurement: Then vs. Now

Dimension	Legacy approach	2026 approach
Household head	One designated “head,” usually male	Reference person, gender-neutral, may rotate
Marital status	Single / married / widowed / divorced only	Adds cohabiting, civil union, same-sex married
Family boundary	Co-resident kin only	Extends to transnational & multi-household families
Data source	Decennial census only	Census + registers + surveys + digital/administrative linkage

Design It: A 2026 Household Roster Question

In groups of 3, sketch a household-roster question set for Thailand's next census that captures: (a) cohabiting partners, (b) same-sex married and unmarried partners, and (c) step/blended relationships — without lengthening the interview beyond 90 seconds.

Report back:

- your relationship-to-reference-person categories
- how you'd handle a respondent who lives with a partner in another household part-time
- one trade-off you accepted

Group size: Groups of 2-3 **Time:** 15-20 min prep + 3 groups × 5 min report-back + 5-10 min synthesis discussion

Assigned Cases

1

What is the primary driver of this location's living-arrangement pattern — economic, demographic, cultural, or measurement/definitional?

2

What downstream policy area (housing, pensions, social protection) is most affected, and how?

GROUP 1

United States

29% of all U.S. households (39.7 million) held one person in 2025 — an all-time high, up from 20% in 1975. Driven by delayed marriage, aging, and rising incomes enabling solo living.

U.S. Census Bureau (2025), Families and Living Arrangements.

GROUP 2

Denmark

About 47% of Danish households are single-person — among the highest shares in the world, reflecting a Nordic welfare state that makes living alone economically feasible at any age.

Esteve, A., & Reher, D. S. (2024), Population and Development Review, 50(1).

GROUP 3

Thailand

28.7% of Thai households were single-person in 2024 (up from a much lower historical base), driven by delayed marriage among urban youth and a rapidly aging population living alone after widowhood.

Euromonitor International (2024); NSO Thailand (2025), 2025 Census.

Downstream Effects on Analysis & Policy



Housing policy

Demand shifts toward smaller units as solo and childless households grow.



Social protection

Pension & health systems built around spousal benefits must adapt to non-marital and solo households.



Population projections

Household (not just population) projections need updated headship-rate assumptions.



Legal recognition

Inheritance, custody, and tax law increasingly must define “family” consistently with statistical practice.

Key Takeaways

1

Household (co-residence) and family (kinship) are distinct statistical concepts — don't conflate them.

2

Marital status is standardly split into never-married and ever-married (married, divorced, widowed); “unmarried” combines the latter three with never-married for exposure analysis.

3

The crude marriage rate is simple but crude; general, age-specific, and SMAM measures correct for population-at-risk problems.

4

Cohabitation, delayed marriage, and one-person households are accelerating, real, and measurable global trends — not fringe cases, and they do not move in lockstep across countries (Group Work 1 & 2).

5

Legal change (e.g., Thailand's 2025 Marriage Equality Act) and survey redesign (e.g., LGBTQ+ categories) directly reshape what demographic data can show.

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BLOCK P

Practice Exercises

18 conceptual, calculation, and applied exercises across four slides — attempt individually, then review with a classmate.

Practice Exercises (1 of 4) · Conceptual

1. Define “household” and “family” and give one real-world example where a person belongs to a household but not a family living with them.
2. A census counts a live-in domestic worker as part of the household but not the family. Explain the statistical logic.
3. List three living-arrangement stages a typical person passes through between age 18 and age 60, in order.
4. Define “ever-married” and explain why it is the complement of “never-married.”
5. Explain why “unmarried/nonmarried” combines never-married, divorced, and widowed persons. When is this grouping analytically useful?

Practice Exercises (2 of 4) · Calculation

6. A district registers 1,850 marriages in a year. Mid-year population is 612,000. Compute the crude marriage rate.
7. Using the district in Q6, if the unmarried population aged 15+ is 198,000, compute the general marriage rate. Compare it to the CMR and explain the gap.
8. Explain one weakness of the crude marriage rate as a comparative measure across two countries with very different age structures.
9. Describe the difference between age-specific marriage rate (ASMR) and singulate mean age at marriage (SMAM). When would you use each?
10. What is a “total first marriage rate,” and how is it conceptually similar to the total fertility rate?

Practice Exercises (3 of 4) · Applied

11. Summarize, in two sentences, why cohabitation is described as a “frontier” in Northern/Central Europe but not (yet) in most of Asia.
12. Using the Thailand marriage-registration data (2022-2024) from this session, calculate the percentage decline from 2022 to 2024.
13. Explain how Thailand's 2025 Marriage Equality Act could create a discontinuity in a time series of the crude marriage rate. How would you flag this for data users?
14. Propose one survey question (with response categories) that would capture “living apart together” couples in a household roster.
15. Discuss: how might rising one-person households change the assumptions demographers use in household projection models?

Practice Exercises (4 of 4) · Group-Work Synthesis

Bring your worked answers, including your Group Work 1 and 2 report-back notes, to the next session for discussion.

16. Compare Japan's and South Korea's 2024 crude marriage rates to Thailand's. Which country's recent trend is most likely to reverse, and why?
17. Using Niger's child-marriage prevalence and one high-income country from Group Work 1, name one measurement challenge each context poses for a standard “age at first marriage” survey question.
18. Drawing on Group Work 2, explain why a rising one-person-household share can reflect three very different underlying stories (economic opportunity, population aging, or delayed union formation) — and why the policy response should differ accordingly.



Questions & Discussion

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